

Headphones aren't optional

You cannot reliably judge recording problems through laptop speakers. Use wired, closed-back headphones while recording. Closed-back designs reduce sound leaking from the headphones back into the microphone, while a cable avoids Bluetooth latency and battery complications.

You do not need luxury audiophile headphones. You need a pair that is comfortable enough for long sessions and sufficiently revealing to expose hum, clipping, mouth noises and connection problems. Audio-Technica's ATH-M20x, for example, was listed by the company's Indian store at ₹4,499–₹5,499 in August 2026.

If you have two speakers, both should ideally monitor. A headphone distribution amplifier may become useful in larger setups.

Do not forget the boring accessories

A great microphone is frustrating without the correct cable or stand.

Budget for:

Mic stand or boom arm: Keeps the microphone close without forcing you to hold it. A boom arm also frees desk space.

Pop filter or foam windscreen: Helps control bursts of air from consonants such as “p” and “b”.

Shock mount: Reduces vibrations transmitted through the table or stand.

XLR cables: Required for XLR microphones. Buy the correct length and keep at least one spare for important recordings.

USB cables and adapters: Check the connectors on your phone, tablet and computer. Do not discover five minutes before an interview that your microphone has USB-C while your older device expects another connection.

Memory cards and batteries: Essential for portable recorders.

Extension board or UPS: Particularly useful if your studio depends on several powered devices or you record in a location with unreliable electricity.

Accessories are where supposedly “₹10,000 setups” often become ₹15,000 setups. Include them in the budget from the beginning.

Add cameras and lights when needed

If video is central to the show, start with the smartphone or camera you already own. Audio should receive the first equipment budget.

A simple video setup needs stable framing, adequate light and enough storage. One camera can capture two hosts if composed carefully. Two or three cameras create editing flexibility but also multiply batteries, memory cards, tripods, file management and synchronisation work.

A basic LED light or window light can improve video more dramatically than an expensive camera in a dark room. Chapter

BUILD YOUR SETUP STEP BY STEP

Use this purchasing sequence:

- **Step 1:** Record a pilot with what you own.
- **Step 2:** Identify the biggest audible problem.
- **Step 3:** Improve the room and microphone position for free.
- **Step 4:** Buy a microphone only if the existing one remains the limitation.
- **Step 5:** Add headphones, stand, pop protection and reliable cables.
- **Step 6:** Move to XLR and an interface when multiple microphones or more control genuinely require it.
- **Step 7:** Add portable recorders, wireless systems, cameras and lighting according to your format.
- **Step 8:** Upgrade only after you can explain what the new equipment will fix.

9 will build the complete video-podcast workflow; at this stage, leave space in your setup for lights and camera angles rather than buying everything immediately.

Buying vs Renting

Rent equipment when you need it occasionally. A creator recording one premium video interview every three months may be better off renting cameras, lights and a studio than owning hardware that spends most of the year in a cupboard.

Buy equipment you use every episode: your primary microphone, headphones, cables and stand.

Before buying used equipment, test connectors, headphone outputs, gain controls and USB ports. For microphones, check for intermittent crackling and physical damage. For battery-powered devices, consider replacement-battery availability.

Your task to figure out

Create a three-column sheet labelled Own, Need Now and Upgrade Later. List every microphone, cable, stand, headphone, computer, phone, recorder, camera and light relevant to your show.

Then assemble the cheapest complete version of the studio and record a two-minute test. Listen on headphones and on your phone speaker. Check voice clarity, background noise, echo, plosives and volume consistency.

Only then decide what to buy. The goal is not to own a studio that looks like a podcast. It is to build the smallest reliable system that lets you produce one consistently. The best podcast setup is ultimately the one that disappears when you press Record and leaves you free to concentrate on the conversation. **d**